

*The diocese of Damiette, Kafr El Sheikh, and Barary
The Monastery of Saint Demiana*



Responding to Jehovah's Witnesses

By Metropolitan Bishoy
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They sanctify the Sabbath (Saturday) with the Jews, they join the Jewish Sadducees in their disbelief regarding the resurrection, and thus eternal judgment of evildoers.

The Jewish Sadducees utterly do not believe in the resurrection of the dead

They also agree with Jewish doctrines regarding the person of Christ .

Jews deny the Sonship of Christ the Lord from God the Father, and His equality to the Father in essence.

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His Eminence Pope Tawadross
Pope Of Alexandria
And Patriarch of the See of Saint Mark (118)

صورة الأنبا بيشوى صفحة ٥ ويكتب تحتها هذه الكتابة

His Eminence Metropolitan Bishoy
Metropolitan of Damiette, Kafr El Sheikh, and Barary
Head of the Monastery of Saint Demiana

Introduction

At present, we have weekly episodes of a program entitled, “Open Discussion” on ME Sat in which we respond to the doctrines of Jehovah’s Witnesses.

We found it beneficial that our Coptic Orthodox Cultural Centre reprints this book, and we thank His Grace Bishop Ermia, general bishop and head of the Coptic Orthodox Cultural Centre.

With the prayers of His Holiness Pope Tawadros II, 118th Pope of Alexandria and Patriarch of the See of Saint Mark.

Bishoy
Metropolitan of Damiette
Kafr El Sheikh and Barary, and
Abbot of the Monastery of Saint Demiana

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Jehovah's Witnesses

Jehovah's Witnesses are one of the most dangerous innovations or sects, who incorrectly consider themselves Christian. They try to associate with Christianity, as Christians, but in reality they are closer to the Jewish religion. They sanctify the Sabbath (Saturday) with the Jews. They join the Jewish Sadducees in their disbelief regarding the resurrection, and thus eternal judgment of evildoers. The Jewish Sadducees utterly do not believe in the resurrection of the dead. They also agree with Jewish doctrines regarding the person of Christ. Jews deny the Sonship of Christ the Lord from God the Father, and His equality to the Father in essence. They refuse to confess that Jesus of Nazareth is Christ the Messiah. Both the Jews and Jehovah's Witnesses agree in denying the divinity of Christ.

There are several other shared issues between Jehovah's Witnesses and the Adventists, which we discussed in lecture five.

The Holy Synod of our Coptic Orthodox Church has declared this Sect Non-Christian in its session on the Saturday that preceded the Pentecost of 1989 AD.

Before we discuss the details of their doctrines, and respond to them, we would like to discuss the history of this Sect's expansion.

Charles Russell and Beginning a New Sect

The founder of the Sect of Jehovah's Witnesses is Charles Taze Russell, an American of Irish descent. He was born in 1852 in Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania. His father was a Protestant Presbyterian. His mother passed away while he was nine years old. He entered school, but did not continue his education beyond his fourteenth year of age. At age sixteen, he joined the Youth Ministry Christian Association and was very active there, for he feared the prospect of death, and the judgment. He began to study the Holy Bible. Doubts blossomed, and planted their bitter and ill thorns in himself, regarding the Christian beliefs of judgement and eternal condemnation, so he separated from the original doctrines of his family.

Protestant doctrines allow each person to present and accept his own interpretation of the Holy books. This is a sure a fertile land for the creation of any innovation; as we saw in the case of William Miller, a Protestant Baptist, who studied the Holy Bible without guidance, which led him to the Adventists' Innovation.

Charles Russell joined the Adventists at the age of eighteen, after attending an Adventist meeting, where the speaker was the infamous Jonas Wendell. After a week of hearing the Seventh-day Adventist speeches, he was extremely comforted by their teachings because they denied the existence of eternal torment for non-repentant evildoers. His relationship with the Adventists lasted two years.

Charles Russell himself confesses that the inception of the sect, in his mind, came while with the Adventists. He wrote that at an Adventist meeting in Allegheny, “There, for the first time, I heard something of the views of Second Adventists, the preacher being Mr. Jonas Wendell.”¹ When he found that the Adventists failed to determine the time of the Second Coming of Christ, he severed relations. However, his relationship with them had deeply imbedded effects on his life and teachings, and is apparent to this day in the teachings of his followers.

After his separation from the Adventists a cluster of his admirers gathered around him. His followers agreed that there was no one who appeared on the stage of creation, who is more masterful in explaining the Holy Bible. From these groups, free circles known as the International Bible Students Association, proceeded. They were dedicated to the study of the Holy Bible in shadow of Russell’s interpretations. These associations were not related to any Christian foundations.

To further his work, embodied in composing and publishing, Russell sold the clothing factory inherited from his parents, and established a printing and publication company, which he called ‘*The Watch Tower*’.

Extremely preoccupied with the prophecies regarding Christ’s Second Coming, and based on his personal

¹ Zion’s Watch Tower, July 15, 1906, Society’s reprints, p. 3821.

studies and interpretations, Russell published his first pamphlet, which was titled *The Object and Manner of The Lord's Return*. He printed approximately 5000 copies, which were the introduction to a chain of books and tracts, that this innovator and his followers published and distributed. Due to their tenacity in distributing his books, they inherited the name, International Bible Students Association, and Tract society.

He established an office, with a seventy-person capacity, wandering from one country to the other spreading his publications and teachings, through the International Bible Students Association, along with thousands of wandering speakers for voluntarily advertisement. Within a few years Russell was able to publicize his beliefs in more than twenty countries worldwide. He became renowned for his prophecies and interpretations regarding the end of the world and the Second Coming of Christ. He devoted all his time and money, for forty years, working for this cause.

He considered 1914 a firm promise for the Second Coming of Christ, and the appearance of the kingdom of God; that Christ will come and reign on earth for one thousand years. He based this prophecy on Nelson Barbour's² calculations. Although Christ did not come in 1914, and this prophecy's falsehood was affirmed, it is still the axis on which the prophecies of Jehovah's Witnesses pivot.

² an Adventists leader

Russell and Barbour published a book in 1877 entitled *The Worlds or Plan for Redemption*. The Watchtower Bible and Tract Society commented on this book: “In this book, the partners, Russell and Barbour, announced their faith that the Second Coming of Christ had actually begun in 1874, which was prolonged by forty years called the period of harvest, and will appear on the face of accuracy in 1914 as the end of the times of the nations.”

Russell and Barbour’s partnership did not last long, due to doctrinal disputations. Thereafter, Russell established his own magazine, ‘*Zion’s Watch Tower and Herald of Christ’s Presence*’. Here appears the relationship between Jehovah’s Witnesses, which were established by Charles Taze Russell, and Zionism.

In 1876, Russell considered himself the shepherd of his followers.

In 1879, he established ‘*Zion’s Watch Tower*’ Magazine.

In 1884, he established a society called *Zion’s Watch Tower Tract Society*.

In 1908, he moved the headquarters of this movement to Brooklyn, New York, where it remains to this day.³

In 1914 Christ did not come, causing an immense embarrassment for Russell, yet the shock did not prevent

³ I have personally seen these headquarters, which sits on a vast amount of land, in the district of Brooklyn. It contains massive buildings, administration office, presses, and establishment, not to be compared with any other organizational structure in the United States, except maybe Boeing’s Airplane Manufacturing plant, or the like. Regarding regular business or religious firms, there are none so expansive.

him from persisting in his calculations and beliefs. He issued a strange interpretation to his followers, to attempt to dig his way out of this embarrassing situation. He declared and issued that, in that year Jesus Christ was crowned king over the earth, as He began His kingly rule by expelling the devils and evil spirits from the heavens, those who fell to earth and set aflame the fire of war in it. In attempting to dig his way out, he claimed that the devils came to earth and ignited World War I. (Did he say that Christ, or the devil will come? This we ask! This is obviously a diversion which he added to his interpretation).

For the followers of this sect the year 1914 was the beginning of a new age, which they called, the time of the end, in which the chosen will be isolated from the evildoers. This is the duty with which they believe God commissioned them.

Russell's Character Flaws

If we wanted to study the personality of the leader of this innovation, Charles Russell, we would find that he is characterized with deceit and swindling in several behavioral and financial situations. He also fell into adultery, which resulted in his wife of twenty-seven years divorcing him. His wife also claimed the gift of prophecy, which caused a kind of competition between both of them.

Russell gave himself the title of priest, although no one ordained him a priest. He proclaimed his knowledge of the Hebrew, Greek, and Latin languages, that he masters these languages, and that he is a graduate of theological schools.

An American priest, in opposition to him, published a booklet, in which he examined these proclamations, and concluded that Russell does not know these languages and is not a priest. Their dispute brought them to the court system. In the High Court session in Hamilton, Ontario, the lawyer (Mr. Staunton) of his foe (Rev. Ross) cornered him, as the judge knew the Greek language. Russell had memorized some segments from the New Testament in the Greek language, to convince people that he had studied the Holy Scriptures in their original languages. So if he said that a certain verse is wrong, or did not occur in the bible, etc. they would believe him. Mr. Staunton placed a copy of the Greek New Testament before the judge. When he originally asked Mr. Russell if he knew the Greek language, he had answered in the affirmative, so he was given the book to read. It was open on page 447, and he was asked only to say the names of the letters written there. Here is an excerpt from the session's transcript:

Q: "Do you know the Greek alphabet?"

A: "Oh yes."

Q: "Can you tell me the correct letters if you see them?"

A: "Some of them. I might make a mistake on some of them."

Q: “Would you tell me the names of those on top of the page, page 447, I have got here?”

A: “Well, I don’t feel that I would be able to.”

Q: “You can’t tell what those letters are? Look at them and see if you know.”

A: “My way – [He was interrupted]

Q: “Are you familiar with the Greek language?”

A: “No.”

His admission in the courtroom was under oath to tell the truth.⁴ On March 17, 1913 the court judged against Russell and for his foe, since the falsehood of his pretence was declared. When they pressured him he cried and confessed that he did not know any of these languages, did not progress beyond his elementary schooling, did not graduate from any theological school, and was not conferred with any clerical degree according to the American or Protestant system.

Being professional in the art of business, which he learned from his father, he purchased inferior American wheat and dyed it with different dyes, calling it ‘Miracle Wheat’ which he claimed yield multiples compared to other kinds. He sold it for a very high price. He might have even claimed that it came from the Holy Land. In harvest season, the farmers who purchased this wheat from him, discovered the falsehood of his claim. Before the same court of Hamilton, they sued him demanding the return of their funds. The court ruled against him,

⁴ We do not agree that a person takes an oath in the courtroom, and in the Egyptian law it is allowed for those whose religion forbids taking an oath, to be waived.

declaring him a swindler and an embezzler, and ordered him to return the funds which he had deceitfully acquired.

The *Brooklyn Daily Eagle* confronted him for his corrupt deeds, in the January 29, 1912 issue. On page sixteen they published the court ruling against him, regarding the 'Miracle Wheat'. He sold 12.5 Kilos of wheat for \$60 (approximate current value = \$6000).

In the divorce case that his wife raised against him, the accusation was that Russell was a selfish controlling dominating person who acted indecently with one of the women. This information is located in several sources, where also are located many confirmations, documents, and proofs thereof, readily available in the court files. His wife, Maria Ackley, raised this suit against him in 1906. She was his personal secretary and general manager, and joined him in releasing several issues of *Zion's Watch Tower Magazine*, but the relationship ended between them in divorce. The court ordered him to pay monthly alimony to his wife. They charged him a sum amount of \$6,036. He attempted to harbor his funds, which at the time amounted to \$5,000,000, amassed from estates and projects, which he smuggled under the name of a shared company so that his wife would not be able to collect.⁵

⁵ This is an example of a person who gave his life to the devil. The devil used him to innovate the furthest doctrinal deviation in the nineteenth century from the Christian faith in the divinity of Christ. This is the worst doctrine currently active with widespread followers.

The Name Jehovah's (YAHWA) Witnesses

In 1931, Judge Joseph Franklin Rutherford, Russell's successor, changed the name of the sect to Jehovah's Witnesses. Rutherford, a judge who also had flaws against him, even in violating his vocation's laws, after the disappointing prophecy of 1914 of Christ's second coming, prophesied that He would come in 1925. When this prophecy was also not fulfilled, he was traumatized and lived with his wife and son unable to appear before people. In his wisdom, however, he organized a convention in Columbus, Ohio in 1931, and called them Jehovah's Witnesses.

What is the significance of the name? They consider that their belief in God is according to His personal name mentioned in the Book of Exodus in the Old Testament. When Moses the prophet asked His name, He responded **"I AM WHO I AM."** In Hebrew אֶהְיֶה אֲשֶׁר אֶהְיֶה (Ahya Asher Ahya), and told him tell your people, *"I AM has sent me to you"* (Ex 3:14). YAHWA (Jehovah) means 'the existing', and AHYA means 'I am'; **"I AM WHO I AM"**. The implication of the expression is that God is the being whose existence is not made or delivered from another; another creator who created Him. However, any other creature aside from God, his being is made or created.

The Angel of the Lord

In fact, as Christians when we read the book of Exodus we find that He who appeared to Moses and told him these words, from a burning bush in the wilderness of Sinai, is the Word of God Himself. The burning bush was a symbol of the incarnation, since the divinity did not burn the humanity, just as the bush did not burn from the fire inflamed within.

Exodus chapter three reads, “*The Angel of the Lord appeared to him (Moses),*” and said, “*I am the God ... of Abraham,*” then He said to him My name is, “*I AM.*” The term ‘*The angel of the Lord*’ can never be applied to the Father, because the term angel in the Hebrew language means ‘messenger’; and the Father sent His Son.

The term angel does not necessarily denote the angels we know. It can be given to a bishop of a church, as for example, “*To the angel of the church of Ephesus ..,*” (Rev 2:1). The bishop, the spiritual hosts who serve the Lord, and whoever is sent as messenger by the Lord, are all called angels. Thus it is clearly impossible to consider the angel who appeared to Moses, and told him my name is *I AM*, and *I AM the God of your fathers*, to be the Father, but the Son.

Jehovah’s Witnesses are self-contradictory since they deny the Son. In the Book of Isaiah God says, “*I, even I, am the Lord, And besides Me there is no savior... You are*

My witnesses, says the Lord, that I am God.” (Is 43:11,12). From this chapter they took their title “Jehovah’s Witnesses”. But, if He says, “I, even I, am the Lord, And besides Me there is no savior,” then who is the savior? The Savior is Jesus Christ, the Only-Begotten Son of God! So, He who says there is no other savior but Me, and you are My witnesses, is the Son, and therefore we are witnesses to Christ. This is why Christ told His disciples, “You shall be witnesses to me” (Acts 1:8). They call themselves Jehovah’s Witnesses, yet deny Christ!

Scriptural Warnings

Saint Peter the Apostle warned saying, *“There will be false teachers among you, who will secretly bring in destructive heresies, even denying the Lord who bought them, and bring on themselves swift destruction”* (2 Pet 2:1). When we speak of the Lord who bought us, we speak of Christ who bought us with His blood. Even they do not deny that Christ was crucified, and that by His crucifixion He carried and made atonement for the sins of the world. Christ is the Lord who bought us; they deny the Lord who bought them by denying the divinity of Christ; thus bringing upon themselves swift destruction. Therefore, anyone who follows Jehovah’s Witnesses brings upon himself swift destruction!

Saint Peter continues, *“And many will follow their destructive ways,”* (2 Pet 2:2) so, there is a warning!

This group began with 25,000 followers in the days of Charles Russell. Currently their number worldwide reached five million or maybe more. This is an observable realization of the verse, “*many will follow their destructive ways.*”

They attempt to proselyte, even in Egypt, although the late president Gamal Abdel-Naser, had passed a law forbidding their activities in Egypt since they were suspected of Zionism. Thus, they have become an unlawful and unrecognized movement in Egypt, regardless, they persist in their activities to convert people going door to door.

Saint John the Beloved also warns that, “*If anyone comes to you and does not bring this doctrine, [the doctrine of truth] do not receive him into your house nor greet him; for he who greets him shares in his evil deeds*” (2 Jn 1: 10-11). Saint John, who always spoke of love, warns us against accepting such heretics and innovators into our homes.

The Coptic Orthodox Church warns her congregation vehemently against Jehovah’s Witnesses, and against accepting any of them into the homes, or even debating with them. They bring the Bible with them and claim to be Christians. Debates with them need someone who is well learned in the Bible and able to respond to their inaccuracies which they assert, using inaccurate interpretations.

† *Dodging Eternal Condemnation*

We will take illustrations of some of the verses which they misinterpret, and respond to their claim, but we again warn that not every person is equipped to dispute them, because they are very clever, and often they have aberrations of the verses themselves, or deviations from the correct interpretation. Debates with them need a person who is well educated and indoctrinated.

The first delusion, which charmed Charles Russell into starting his innovation, as we have mentioned, was his fear of eternal punishment and condemnation. This indicates that this person was defeated by certain sins, of which he was unable to repent. Any person who lives a life of repentance would not be terrified of the eternal judgment, especially if he has a loving relationship with God. He continues in the fear of God however, lest he becomes slack and careless, or forgets the importance of repentance and keeping vigil.

Russell's proclamation induces people to underestimate sin, catapulting them towards slackness, not keeping vigils, and non-repentance. This is similar to what the Epicureans said: "*Let us eat and drink, for tomorrow we die!*" (Is 22:10). If there is no eternal condemnation and no resurrection for evildoers, then any person living in sin and enjoying it, has no desire for another life since he enjoyed this one to the fullest.

Christ's words regarding this issue were very clear when He was speaking of the judgment: *"When the Son of Man comes in His glory, and all the holy angels with Him, then He will sit on the throne of His glory. All the nations will be gathered before Him, and He will separate them one from another, as a shepherd divides his sheep from the goats. And He will set the sheep on His right hand, but the goats on the left"* (Mt 25:31-33). Here it is obvious that in His Second Coming, Christ will separate between the good and the evil. He continues: *"Then He will also say to those on the left hand, 'Depart from Me, you cursed, into the everlasting fire prepared for the devil and his angels: for I was hungry and you gave Me no food; I was thirsty and you gave Me no drink;'"* (Mt 25:41-42). It is clear here that Christ will judge the evildoers. He confirmed this again by saying, *"And these will go away into everlasting punishment, but the righteous into eternal life"* (Mt 25:46).

✝ *The Death of the Soul*

As we mentioned in the previous lecture on the Adventists, they claim that the soul dies with the body. This is the element that attracted Charles Russell to them, therefore Jehovah's Witnesses also share this erroneous doctrine, and we refute it just as zealously.

We have also expounded upon the doctrine of resurrection. When asked whose wife the woman who married seven brothers will be in the resurrection,

Christ's response to the Sadducees was, "*You are mistaken, not knowing the Scriptures nor the power of God*" (Mt 22:29). He added, "*God is not the God of the dead, but of the living*" (Mt 22:32), confirming to them that the soul does not die. In other words the human soul does not die with the body! This is one of Jehovah's Witnesses' and the Adventists' major heresies.⁶

✝ *The Divinity of Jesus Christ*

One of the major heresies of Jehovah's Witnesses (originally established by Charles Russell) is the denial of the divinity of Jesus Christ. This is a very dangerous heresy, because it nullifies the entire doctrine of salvation and redemption.

The denial of the divinity of Christ is a fragment of the larger heresy believed by the Arians and Jehovah's Witnesses: the denial of the Trinity (the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit as one God).

When we speak of the Incarnation of the Only-Begotten Son, His Crucifixion, and Resurrection from the dead, we do not mean that the Father was incarnated. The Son **is** the One who was incarnated; there is a distinction between the Person of the Father, the Person of the Son, and the Person of the Holy Spirit. At the same time, the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit are one divine

⁶ Whoever would like to search for the responses to these points may refer back to lecture five of the Simplifying Faith Lecture Series.

nature, one Godhead ‘*We worship Him and glorify Him,*’ as we recite in the Prime prayer. The Divine Essence is one, and indivisible. God the being, YAHWA, as we previously explained, is one. So, the Father is YAHWA, the Son is YAHWA, and the Holy Spirit is YAHWA. This indivisible being is the One Triune God of three persons: the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit.

Denying the divinity of Jesus Christ, contradicts the saying of the Lord, “*I, even I, am the Lord, And besides Me there is no savior,*” (Is 43:11). Further, it challenges whether the sacrifice of the cross would be sufficient for the salvation of the world. Often, when speaking of Himself in the Old Testament, the Lord says, I am “*The Lord, your Redeemer, The Holy One of Israel:*” (Is 43:14). The Lord is the redeemer, and the savior. This is also clearly stated in the New Testament: “*But when the kindness and the love of God our Savior toward man appeared, not by works of righteousness which we have done, but according to His mercy He saved us, through the washing of regeneration and renewing of the Holy Spirit, whom He poured out on us abundantly through Jesus Christ our Savior,*” (Tit 3:4-6). This verse speaks of: *the love of God our Savior* (God the Father), *the renewing of the Holy Spirit* (God the Holy Spirit and His work in the salvation), *through Jesus Christ our Savior* (God the Son, who is Jesus Christ the Savior): the Trinity.

The Triune God is the savior! The Father is our savior because He sent His only-begotten Son for the salvation

of the world, *“For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life”* (Jn 3:16). The Son is the savior because He said, *“I lay down My life for the sheep”* (Jn 10:15), also *“By this we know love, because He laid down His life for us”* (1 Jn 3 16). The Holy Spirit is our savior *“through the washing of regeneration and renewing”* of Baptism and His work in all the sacraments of the Church.

Denying the divinity of Christ completely destroys the meaning of Christianity, and occasions for the insufficiency of the sacrifice on the cross to save the entire world, rendering it unable to pay the debt that leads to eternal condemnation. If the eternal condemnation reserved for millions of people is immeasurable and uncountable, then the sacrifice which is offered must also be unlimited, because Christ said, *“And I give them [my sheep] eternal life”* (Jn 10:28), as we mentioned in the second lecture of the Simplifying Faith Lecture Series.

✝ *Corrupting The Scriptures*

In their attack against the divinity of Christ, they primarily rely on the misuse of certain verses. It is said that ‘the insane deceive the sane’; those who are sane may actually be affected when they hear their interpretations of some verses.

“My Father is greater than I” (Jn 14: 28)

For example, they abandon the verse that says, "***I and My Father are one***" (Jn 10:30), and cling to His saying that, "***My Father is greater than I***" (Jn 14:28). Of course Christ did not say this verse without preludes. The verse begins with: "***If you loved Me, you would rejoice because I said, 'I am going to the Father,' for My Father is greater than I***" (Jn 14:28). He said this while He was on earth, present in the flesh. Therefore our teacher Saint Paul the apostle wrote that Christ the Lord, "*Made Himself of no reputation, taking the form of a bondservant.*"

He writes, "*Let this mind be in you which was also in Christ Jesus, who, being in the form of God, did not consider it robbery to be equal with God, but made Himself of no reputation, taking the form of a bondservant, and coming in the likeness of men. And being found in appearance as a man, He humbled Himself and became obedient to the point of death, even the death of the cross. Therefore God also has highly exalted Him and given Him the name which is above every name, that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, of those in heaven, and of those on earth, and of those under the earth, and that every tongue should confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father*" (Phil 2:5-11).

“Being in the form of God,” here the word *form*, in the original Greek text of the New Testament does not

appear as εἰκὼν (eikon=icon) meaning an ordinary image, but μορφή (Morfy) signifying the nature along with the image, therefore it was translated by the word 'form' in English. Hence, the phrase means "being in the nature of God" and also "in the image of God", since it is written that Christ the Lord, "*is the image of the invisible God*" (Col 1:15). His nature is a divine glorified nature. When Christ the Lord incarnated, He retained and sustained His divine glory, yet He concealed His glory at His unity with the humanity.

"Who, being in the form of God, did not consider it robbery to be equal with God, but made Himself of no reputation, taking the form of a bondservant and coming in the likeness of men." In this form He was beaten, nailed, and scourged; so, in the form in which He suffered, we can not say that He was in the glorified divine image, but was in the image of *no reputation*. He concealed His glory, therefore it is written, "*And being found in appearance as a man, He humbled Himself and became obedient to the point of death, even the death of the cross.*"

So, when He says, "*greater than I,*" He means greater than His current condition, where He is in *the form of a bondservant*. This form had exceedingly less glory than the glory of the Father. However, regarding His divinity He never separated from the Father, and was never divided from the Father (One Divinity and One Nature of the three Persons).

Christ revealed in the same Gospel that He had a different glory than that with which He appeared on earth by saying to the Father, “*And now, O Father, glorify Me together with Yourself, with the glory which I had with You before the world was,*” (Jn 17:5). This glory that He had with the Father before the creation of the world was not apparent during the time of His passion on earth. As if He wanted to ask His disciples, ‘Why are you sad that I’m going to the Father? Would anyone be upset that his beloved returns to His original glory? My original glory is greater than the glory with which I appear now.’

On the Mount of Transfiguration, He revealed a ray of His glory, but not His full glory, because He said, “*No man shall see Me, and live*” (Ex 33:20). Had He revealed His full glory, all the disciples would have died. When can man see the full glory of God? When he puts on the spiritual resurrected body, with which he will enter eternal life; “*For we shall see Him as He is*” (1 Jn 3:2). When Saint John says, “*We beheld His glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father, full of grace and truth*” (Jn 1:14), he is speaking of a glimpse of that glory. As for His full glory, it is utterly impossible for any person to endure its sight.

Prophet Moses begged, “*Please, show me Your glory... But He said, You cannot see My face; for no man shall see Me, and live. And the Lord said, Here is a place by Me, and you shall stand on the rock. So it shall be, while My glory passes by, that I will put you in the cleft of the*

rock, and will cover you with My hand while I pass by. Then I will take away My hand, and you shall see My back; but My face shall not be seen.” (Exo 33:18, 20-23). Moses was commanded to go into the cleft, and God would place His hand on him. After He passes, Moses was to see His back. He wanted to tell him, you **cannot** see My full glory.

When Christ appeared to Saul of Tarsus on his way to Damascus, certainly He appeared to him in glory. The result was that Saul lost his sight; blindness is a progression toward death. When he was baptized, something like scales fell from his eyes (see Acts 9:18), this means God created a new Cornea to replace the one which was burned, as a result of seeing a degree of Christ's glory. Had the measure increased slightly, Saul would have lost not only his Cornea, but his whole eye, his cranium with all its contents, and his entire bodily composition. He cannot continue living with this body.

If a person clings onto a 12 volt electric current he feels a slight jolt, if 110 volts he could shake and quiver, and if he persists for a long time he might die. If he held onto 220 volts, the shock would be even greater, and if 11000 he instantly dies. If he simply passes under the 500,000 volt wire that runs from the High Dam (being not a great distance away, but enough for a gap between him and the electric shock, on an elevated platform, a trellis for example) he could die without even touching the wire, being meters away. Therefore it is illegal for high voltage wires to pass in mountain areas, or else they have

to dig below and vacate, so anyone walking by, will not die.

The issue of “*My Father is greater than I*” (Jn 14:28), to which Jehovah’s Witnesses cling is full of deception. All the verses mentioned in the Holy Bible about Christ the Lord, which Jehovah’s Witnesses use, to attempt to diminish the prominence of our Lord Jesus Christ, or to prove that He is not equal to the Father in essence, are verses which He said regarding His incarnation, humanity, and emptying Himself of His privilege. They were never said regarding His divinity, because His divinity does not change due to the incarnation.

He made His humanity ‘*one with His divinity without mingling, without confusion, and without alteration*’ (the creed of faith). The unity of the divinity with the humanity did not change the humanity into divinity. He was able to feel pain when He was scourged. Or, as Saint Paul the apostle writes, “*He, by the grace of God, might taste death for everyone*” (Heb 2:9). So then, in dying, He died according to the flesh, and in suffering He suffered according to the flesh.

We recite in the prayer of the ninth hour, ‘*O who in the ninth hour tasted death in the flesh for our sake, we the sinners*’, but at the same time, we also recite, ‘*Holy God, Holy Mighty, Holy Immortal, who was crucified for us, have mercy on us*’. We mean immortal according to His divinity; accepting death according to His humanity,

because He came especially to pay the debt and be crucified a ransom for the world.

“Why do you call Me good? No one is good but One”

There is yet another verse they abuse. When the young rich man came and knelt before Jesus, he asked, “**Good Teacher, what good thing shall I do that I may have eternal life? So He** [Jesus Christ] **said to him, Why do you call Me good? No one is good but One, that is, God.** But if you want to enter into life, keep the commandments. ...*The young man said to Him, All these things I have kept from my youth... Jesus said to him, If you want to be perfect, go, sell what you have and give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven; and come, follow Me. But when the young man heard that saying, he went away sorrowful, for he had great possessions*” (Mt 19: 16-22).

They claim that Jesus’ question to the young man, “*Why do you call Me good? No one is good but One, that is, God*”, is proof that He is not God. The Bible says, “*Great is the mystery of godliness: God was manifested in the flesh*” (1 Tim 3:16). They reject this verse and cling to the previous. Besides this, there is much that shows that our Lord Jesus Christ is God the incarnate Word.

Our Lord Jesus Christ did not tell him, ‘**Do not** call me good’, but, ‘**Why** do you call Me good’. The word *why* does not denote negation, but indicates inquisition or investigation, as to the means by which this youth is speaking to Him. Is he aware that Christ the Lord is the incarnate God? Will he obey Him when He instructs him to go sell all his possessions, or is he simply addressing Him as he addresses any Jewish teacher, scribe, pharisee, or high priest?

Proof that Jesus Christ did not reject the title ‘*Good Teacher*’, is in His own words, “*I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd gives His life for the sheep*” (Jn 10:11). Who dares say that our Lord Jesus Christ rejects goodness for Himself? Did He not tell the Jews, “*Which of you convicts Me of sin*” (Jn 8:48)?

At the eternal judgment He will tell the servant who did the will of God and kept His commandments, “*Well done, good and faithful servant; you have been faithful over a few things, I will make you ruler over many things*” (Mt 25:23). He calls the servant, “**good servant**”! In both verses the Greek text uses the same term: ἀγαθος. Is there a discrepancy between the two utterances? When our Lord Jesus Christ was on earth, no one on earth could have been called “good” except Him, because it is written,

“They have all turned aside; They have together become unprofitable; There is none who does good, no, not one” (Rom 3:12).

When Christ came, He said, *“Which of you convicts Me of sin?”* (Jn 8:48), and it is known that Jesus Christ is the only one who is without sin, as Saint Paul wrote, *“Therefore, in all things He had to be made like His brethren... yet without sin”* (Heb 2:17, 4:15).

Also, in his epistle to the Romans, Saint Paul the apostle wrote, *“But now the righteousness of God apart from the law is revealed, being witnessed by the Law and the Prophets, even the righteousness of God, through faith in Jesus Christ, to all and on all who believe”*, (Rom 3:21-22).

He said of Adam, *“Therefore, just as through one man sin entered the world, and death through sin, and thus death spread to all men, because all sinned”* (Rom 5:12). If *“all sinned”*, then who can be called ‘good’? Yet, he continued in verse fifteen, *“For if by the one man's offense many died, much more the grace of God and the gift by the grace of the one Man, Jesus Christ, abounded to many.”* He continues, *“For if by the one man's offense [Adam] death reigned through the one, much more those who receive abundance of grace and of the gift of righteousness will reign in life through the One, Jesus Christ. Therefore, as through one man's offense judgment came to all men, resulting in condemnation, even so through one Man's righteous act [only one, and no other] the free gift came to all men, resulting in justification of life. For as by one man's disobedience many were made sinners, so also by one Man's obedience many will be made righteous.”* (Rom 5: 17-

19). Here it is clear, that the only one who could be ascribed with complete ultimate righteousness is Christ the Lord.

How will He say, *“Well done, good and faithful servant”* if no one is good except one: God? Because He will not say this to man while He is here on earth. Here on earth He says, *“They have all turned aside; They have together become unprofitable; There is none who does good, no, not one.”* He will say *“Well done, good and faithful servant”* as the person enters eternity; *“Being justified freely by His grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus”* (Rom 3:22). *“Blessed are those whose lawless deeds are forgiven, And whose sins are covered; Blessed is the man to whom the Lord shall not impute sin”* (Rom 4: 7-8); so, the person entering eternity has been washed, made righteous, and his sins have been blotted out.

He says, *“I have blotted out, like a thick cloud, your transgressions,”* (Is 44:22). Since his transgressions have been blotted out, upon entering eternity he may hear the expression *“Good servant”*. But while still suffering here on earth, it is impossible to say this person is *“Good”*. Why? He said, *“No one is good but One, that is, God”*.

Even if the title were given, it would not be given before completion of the salvation, because when Christ came, all were under condemnation; so, no one was *good*, except one, Who is our Lord Jesus Christ alone. The

utmost we can say, after the fulfillment of the redemption, is that some people are *good* and righteous. Of course, we can only entitle a person as '*good*' who has been crowned with righteousness, after completing his struggle. The question is also a proportional one. We have never heard of anyone entitled as '*good*', except our Lord Jesus Christ; unless maybe the victorious saints after being crowned with righteousness. He says to him, "*Well done, good and faithful servant; you have been faithful over a few things, I will make you ruler over many things. Enter into the joy of your lord*".

He says, "*No one is good but One, that is, God*". So what is in this verse? We know that of all humans *not one* is good in the sense of complete goodness, except our Lord Jesus Christ. Therefore, this verse, "*No one is good but One, that is, God*", proves that **Jesus Christ is God**, the "*One*".

Example: Two strangers meet and one salutes the other, "Hello doctor". The doctor responds, "Why are you calling me a doctor?" He asks the question to know how the other found out that he was a doctor. Is it simply a title he uses to anyone, or does he truly know that he is a doctor? So, when Christ the Lord asks the young man, '*Why do you call Me good*', he does not mean, 'Do not call me good'.

✝ *Denying the Divinity of Holy Spirit*

Jehovah's Witnesses' declarations that deny our Lord Jesus Christ's divinity also deny the divinity of the Holy Spirit. In denying Christ the Lord they are, "*Denying the Lord who bought them*" (2 Pt 2:1), as we mentioned.

In denying the Holy Spirit, they deny that He is a hypostasis, or one of the three hypostaseis, or that He is God. **They simply consider the Holy Spirit a power.** In their infamous book, *The New World Translation of the Holy Scriptures* (their own interpretation), they translate, "*The earth was without form, and void; and darkness was on the face of the deep. And **the Spirit of God** was hovering over the face of the waters*" (Gen 1:2), as 'and **the power of God** was hovering over the face of the waters'.

When we refer to the original Hebrew text, we find written, רוּחַ אֱלֹהִים (Ro,ah Elohim) which means 'the spirit of God'. In Hebrew, the word 'power' is, כֹּחַ (Ko,ah), yet the difference between the ר (R) and the כ (K) is very obvious in Hebrew! They changed the scriptures to their liking, and they do this in several places of the Bible, and therefore we do not rely on their translation.

That the Holy Spirit is a Hypostasis of the Trinity and is Divine has many proofs⁷. Our Lord Jesus Christ said,

⁷ We may discuss the issue of the Holy Spirit's Divinity and Hypostasis in another lecture dedicated for that purpose. We may also devote a separate lecture to Biblical evidences of the Divinity of our

“The Spirit of truth who proceeds from the Father, He will testify of Me” (Jn 15:26). The Holy Spirit Himself spoke and said, “Now separate to Me Barnabas and Saul” (Acts 13:2). When Ananias and Sapphira lied to Saint Peter, he told them, “You have not lied to men but to God... How is it that you have agreed together to test the Spirit of the Lord? ” (Acts 5: 3,9). One time he said, ‘you lied to God’, and another time he said, ‘you test the Spirit’; therefore Saint Peter considers that they lied to the Holy Spirit, Who is God.

✝ *Angels and Humans*

Another of Jehovah’s Witnesses’ errors is their belief that angels marry humans. They rely on a severe misinterpretation on what is written in the Book of Genesis: *“Now it came to pass, when men began to multiply on the face of the earth, and daughters were born to them, that the sons of God saw the daughters of men, that they were beautiful; and they took wives for themselves of all whom they chose. And the Lord said, My Spirit shall not strive with man forever, for he is indeed flesh; yet his days shall be one hundred and twenty years. There were giants on the earth in those days, and also afterward, when the sons of God came in to the daughters of men and they bore children to them. Those were the mighty men who were of old, men of renown.” (Gen 6:1-4).* After this God caused the flood.

Lord Jesus Christ, although we discussed it in the first lecture when we spoke about the Incarnation, redemption, and the Holy Trinity.

They interpret the sons of God as angels, and the daughters of men as humans. Of course, the sons of God are the saintly descendents of Seth, and the daughters of men are the descendents of Cain. God did not want the children of saintly Seth to mingle with the daughters of murderous Cain, to whom God has said, *“The voice of your brother's blood cries out to Me from the ground. So now you are cursed from the earth, which has opened its mouth to receive your brother's blood from your hand.”* (Gen 4: 10-11). The proclamation, *“You are cursed”*, alone is sufficient to signify that he was no longer considered one of the children of God. Similarly the devil, before the fall, was considered one of the angels, and could have been considered one of the children of God, but once he fell and God cursed him, he could no longer be described as such.

They say that the angels looked at women when they were bathing. They say this! They even drew a picture of this incident in their books! The angels liked the appearance of the women, so they lusted for them, came and married them as a result of this sexual lust.

Christ candidly stated that, *“In the resurrection they neither marry nor are given in marriage, but are like angels of God in heaven”* (Mt 22: 33). This is Christ's statement, which completely frankly negates that angels could marry.

† *Governments are From the Devil*

They publish books that declare their mistaken belief that the governing authorities are from the devil. Of course, this contradicts the Holy Bible: *“Let every soul be subject to the governing authorities. For there is no authority except from God, and the authorities that exist are appointed by God. Therefore whoever resists the authority resists the ordinance of God, and those who resist will bring judgment on themselves”* (Rom 13:1-2). Their belief that governing authorities are from the devil is an obvious contradiction to the Holy Bible. It is true that, *“We ought to obey God rather than men”* (Acts 5:29). If the governing authority gives me a command that contradicts God’s commandments, I am not called to obey, but as long as there is no contradictions, then I must obey the authorities regardless of their religious affiliation.

† *The Pledge to the Flag*

They prohibit the nation’s pledge to the flag, and consider it idolatrous worship. This also is in contradiction to the governing authorities.

† *Blood Transfusion*

They also prohibit blood transfusions, to the point that in America, there were law suits raised against parents who

refused blood transfusions to their children who were in accidents. I have personally seen court procedures regarding an American family that refused a blood transfusion for their daughter who was in an accident. Courts fine against them in these lawsuits.

They refer their prohibition of blood transfusions to God's forbiddance of eating blood, when He said: "*The life of the flesh is in the blood*" (Lev 17:11). Also, in the New Testament, "*Abstain from things offered to idols, from blood, from things strangled, and from sexual immorality*" (Acts 15: 29). So, it is prohibited in the Old Testament and New Testament for a person to eat anything with its blood. The blood of all sacrifices must be drained out on the floor.

There is a great difference between eating a European bloody sausage (which is a sin), and accepting blood transfusion to save someone's life. With the prohibition of blood transfusions, comes the prohibition of organ transplants. Due to their prohibitions many people may die, which is unacceptable. God never prohibited saving man's life; he prohibited the craving that drives a person to eat blood.

This also prepares us in the New Testament to take life from the blood of Christ, and not from the blood of any animal, for, "*The life of the flesh is in the blood*". This has a spiritual significance; partaking of Christ's body and blood.

† *The Church as Idolatrous Worship*

They consider paying homage to icons, kissing crosses, and the Holy liturgy, as idolatrous worship. They consider that our believe that the bread and wine in the holy liturgy are the true body and true blood of our Lord Jesus Christ, as idolatrous worship. The homage to icons and bowing down to worship before the alter, as idolatrous worship.

In the psalms it is written, “*But as for me, I will come into Your house in the multitude of Your mercy; In fear of You I will worship toward Your holy temple*” (Ps 5:7), was this also idolatrous worship? They consider everything in the church, even kissing the cross, idolatrous worship. They say the church is a dwelling for the devil, and forbid and prohibit their followers from entering churches. This is to the extreme that if Jehovah’s Witnesses converted a person, and a family member was getting married, he would not attend the wedding, but would wait outside to congratulate the wedding couple.

† *Zionist Funding*

They also use Zionist funding from Israeli, and there is substantial evidence in many assemblies that they have relations with a Zionist nation. Jehovah’s Witnesses use these funds to entice people and lure them with the wealth and positions they could offer them. They send

hired persons, a man and a woman whom they consider evangelists, to knock on the door and deceive people saying, ‘We are coming to read Holy Bible together. Would you mind?’ They begin in Egypt with Vandyke’s Beirutic interpretation, which is the usual well spread Arabic publication of the bible, and not their own interpretation. Opening to a specific chapter and verse, they point to verses such as the ones we have discussed: “*My Father is greater than I*” or, “*Why do you call Me good?*” In this deceptive and cunning way they begin to place doubts in the minds of people of many doctrines.

✝ *The Danger of Using a Single Verse*

Such verses as, “*My Father is greater than I*”, need to be read alongside, “*O Father, glorify Me together with Yourself, with the glory which I had with You before the world was*” (Jn 17:15), besides many other verses which prove Christ’s Divinity. Other examples are, “*No one has ascended to heaven but He who came down from heaven, that is, the Son of Man who is in heaven*” (Jn 3:13). And, “*For where two or three are gathered together in My name, I am there in the midst of them*” (Mt 18:20), which means that Christ can be present in all places. Also, “*I am with you always, even to the end of the age*” (Mt 28: 20), which means Christ is present in every place and at every time. So, their use of specific verses reveals the danger of using one verse. This shows that we need our Biblical reading to be abundant, informed, and collective (analyzing all its verses), so as

not to fall into the traps and deceptions of such evil persons.

✝ *Christ's Resurrection*

Another of the absurd claims of Jehovah's Witnesses is that when our Lord Jesus Christ resurrected from the dead, He did not rise in His crucified body, but rose as a spiritual being with a glorified image. As for His body, either it decomposed into gases and disappeared, or God concealed it from view in an unknown place as a memorial to His redemptive work when He was crucified. His resurrection for them means that God created a spirit for Him, because they also believe in the death of the spirit with the body. So, God created a glorified spirit for Him, with which He rose. Their reason is that His appearance changed after the resurrection.

Christ's appearance also changed on the Mount of Transfiguration! And, when the Jews tried to stone Him, the Bible says, "*Jesus hid Himself and went out of the temple, going through the midst of them, and so passed by*" (Jn 8:59), so He passed through the midst of them and they did not even see Him. The issue is not only after the resurrection. Analogous to walking on the water, Christ may, through a miraculous work change His appearance. It is not necessary that *His* appearance changes, because in the incident of His appearance to the disciples of Emmaus it is written that, "*Their eyes were*

restrained, so that they did not know Him". His appearance did not change, but their eyes were unable to recognize Him!

✠ Evidence of Christ's Resurrection from the Dead

Very obvious evidence that Christ rose from the dead: *"Jesus came and stood in the midst, and said to them, Peace be with you. When He had said this, He showed them His hands and His side. Then the disciples were glad when they saw the Lord" (Jn 20:19-20). Also, "Behold My hands and My feet, that it is I Myself. Handle Me and see, for a spirit does not have flesh and bones as you see I have" (Lk 24:39). Deception is not possible when Christ said to Thomas, "Reach your finger here, and look at My hands; and reach your hand here, and put it into My side. Do not be unbelieving, but believing" (Jn 20:27).*

Even during the days of Saint Paul the Apostle there were people who denied the Resurrection, therefore he wrote, *"Now if Christ is preached that He has been raised from the dead, how do some among you say that there is no resurrection of the dead? But if there is no resurrection of the dead, then Christ is not risen. And if Christ is not risen, then our preaching is empty and your faith is also empty. Yes, and we are found false witnesses of God, because we have testified of God that He raised up Christ, whom He did not raise up -- if in*

fact the dead do not rise. For if the dead do not rise, then Christ is not risen. And if Christ is not risen, your faith is futile; you are still in your sins! Then also those who have fallen asleep in Christ have perished. If in this life only we have hope in Christ, we are of all men the most pitiable. But now Christ is risen from the dead, and has become the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep” (1 Cor 15:12-20).

The Resurrection is an essential cornerstone of the Christian faith. Even regarding His Second Coming Christ said, *“They will see the Son of Man coming on the clouds of heaven with power and great glory”* (Mt 24:30). Also, *“Behold, He is coming with clouds, and every eye will see Him, even they who pierced Him. And all the tribes of the earth will mourn because of Him”* (Rev 1:7). Zechariah prophesied, *“They will look on Me whom they pierced”* (Zec 12:10). How can we link the piercing and the traces of the nails to the resurrected body, if not the same crucified body rose? The denial of Christ’s bodily resurrection offsets the whole Christian faith!

Regarding the two who denied the resurrection Saint Paul wrote, *“They overthrow the faith of some”* (2 Tim 2:18). This claim alone, according to all the Holy Scriptures and Apostolic teachings, is sufficient to prove that Jehovah’s Witnesses overthrow the entire faith. He writes, *“And if Christ is not risen, then our preaching is empty and your faith is also empty”* (1 Cor 15: 14). Christianity spread preaching the resurrection. When

they came to choose a disciple to replace Judas Iscariot they said, *“One of these must become a witness with us of His resurrection”* (Acts 1:22).

Christ said, *“You shall be witnesses to Me in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth”* (Acts 1:8), because He is Jehovah. The most important witness is the witness to the Resurrection! Jehovah’s Witnesses are not witnesses that Christ is the Lord who bought them, nor do they witness to His Resurrection from the dead. So, when they claim that they are Jehovah’s Witnesses, we respond, ‘No, you are not Witnesses of Jehovah’. This is an outright lie! One who wants to witness to Jehovah needs to witness that Christ **is** Jehovah Who purchased us with His blood, and died on the cross according to the flesh, and resurrected from the dead on the third day as the Bible witnesses.

In the church, we live, and savor experiencing Christ’s death and Resurrection. The entire congregation cries fervently, *‘Your death O Lord we proclaim, Your Holy Resurrection and Ascension into the heavens, we confess’*. Saint Paul wrote, *“For as often as you eat this bread and drink this cup, you proclaim the Lord's death till He comes”* (1 Cor 11:26), *“That I may know Him and the power of His resurrection, and the fellowship of His sufferings”* (Phil 3:10).

Without the Resurrection, our lives with Christ have no meaning. This is the life which Christianity evangelized; Christianity did not evangelize death without

resurrection. Christ's death without Resurrection from the dead would have been a great disaster and embarrassment. Because they know that His Resurrection is the strongest evidence of His Divinity, they deny His Resurrection. Therefore Saint Paul wrote, *"And declared to be the Son of God with power according to the Spirit of holiness, by the resurrection from the dead"*. The Resurrection is the delight of the Saints, the joy of the righteous, and the hope of eternal life.

Glory to God forever, Amen.

